Group A Strep Infection

About Strep Throat

JAN. 15, 2026 • ESPAÑOL

For Everyone

KEY POINTS

- Strep throat is a bacterial infection in the throat and tonsils.
- Healthcare providers can do a quick test to see if a sore throat is strep throat.
- Antibiotics can help people with strep throat feel better faster.
- Speak with a healthcare provider if you have concerns about strep throat.



What it is

Strep throat is a bacterial infection in the throat and tonsils.

Worried your sore throat may be strep throat?

Viruses cause most sore throats. Only around **1 in 10 adults** and **3 in 10 children** with a sore throat have strep throat.

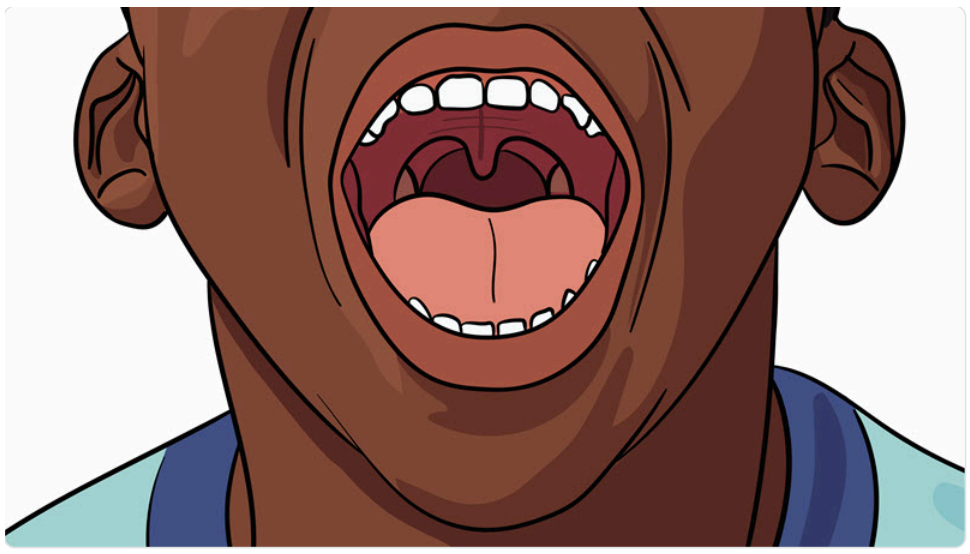
Learn which symptoms point to a viral infection

Symptoms

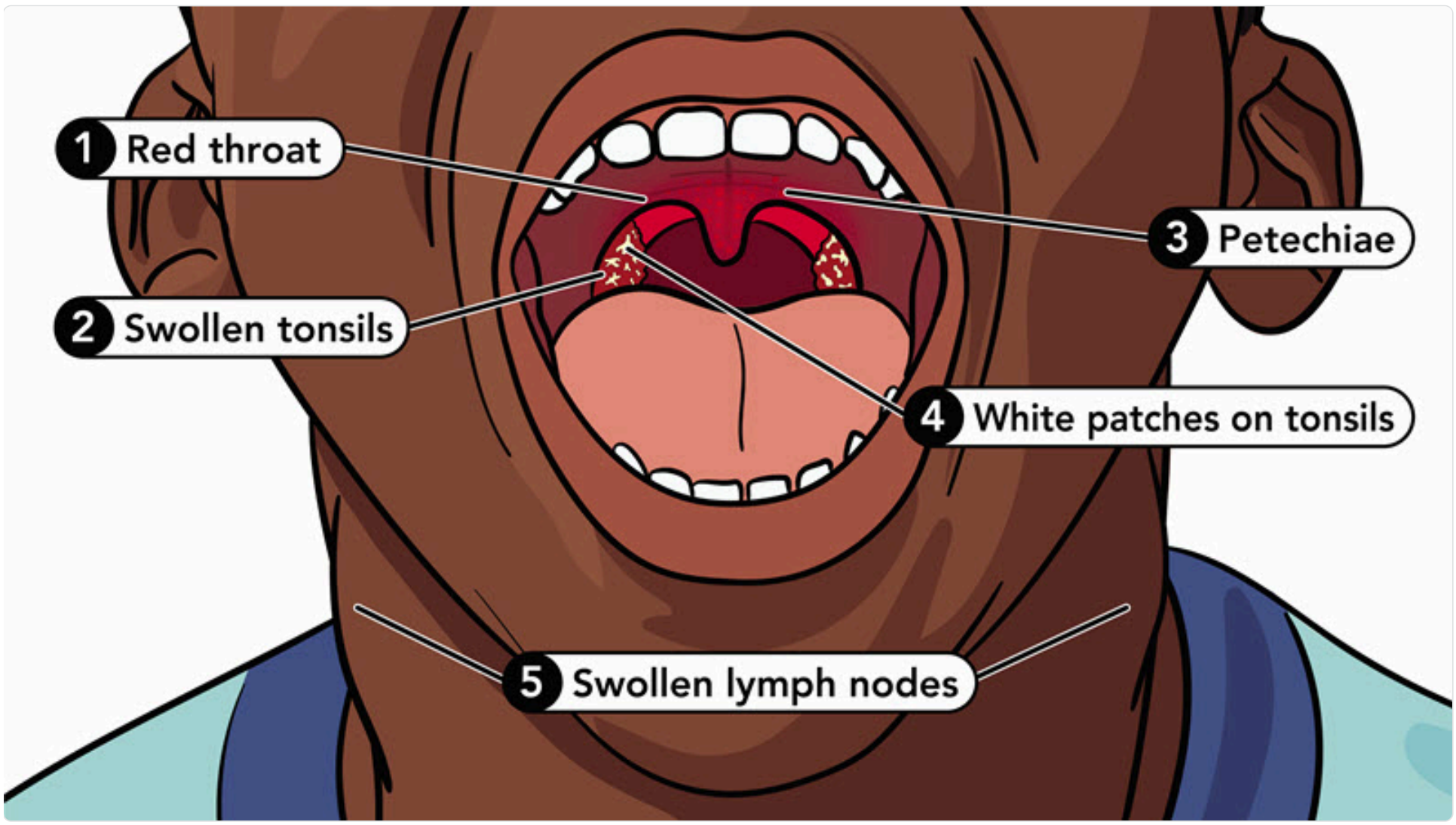
It usually takes 2 to 5 days after exposure to become ill with strep throat.

Common symptoms may include:

- Fever
- Pain when swallowing
- Red and swollen tonsils
- Sore throat that started very quickly and may look red
- Swollen lymph nodes in the front of the neck
- Tiny, red spots on the roof of the mouth, called petechiae
- White patches or streaks of pus on the tonsils



See what a healthy throat looks like.



Swelling, redness, and white patches are common symptoms of strep throat.

Less common symptoms, especially for children, may include:

- Headache
- Nausea or vomiting
- Rash (scarlet fever)
- Stomach pain

Complications

Complications can occur after a strep throat infection if the bacteria spread to other parts of the body.

Complications can include:

- Abscesses (pockets of pus) around the tonsils or in the neck
- Ear infections
- Post-streptococcal glomerulonephritis (a kidney disease)
- Rheumatic fever (a disease affecting the heart, joints, brain, skin)
- Sinus infections

Risk factors

Anyone can get strep throat, but some factors increase the risk of getting it.

Age

Strep throat is **more common in children** than adults.

- **Most common**: Children 5 through 15 years old
- **Rare**: Children younger than 3 years old

Close contact

Close contact with another person with strep throat is the **most common risk factor** for illness. For example, if someone has strep throat, the bacteria often spread to other people in their household.

Contact with children: Parents of school-age children and adults who are often in contact with children are at increased risk.

Crowded settings can increase the risk of getting any group A strep infection including strep throat. These settings include:

- Daycare centers and schools
- Detention or correctional facilities
- Homeless shelters
- Military training facilities

Causes

Group A *Streptococcus* (group A strep bacteria) cause strep throat and are **contagious**.

KEEP READING
Causes and How the Bacteria Spread

Prevention

People can take steps to help protect themselves and others from group A strep infections, including strep throat. These steps include:

- Wash hands often with soap and water
- Avoid sharing cups, utensils, and bites of food with people who are sick
- Wash cups, utensils, and plates after someone who's sick uses them
- Cover coughs and sneezes
- Keep wounds clean and bandaged
- Seek health care if you think you have a group A strep infection

KEEP READING
Preventing Group A Strep Infection

Testing and diagnosis

Healthcare providers can use **several types of tests** to diagnose strep throat.

KEEP READING
Testing for Strep Throat or Scarlet Fever

Treatment and recovery

Healthcare providers treat strep throat with antibiotics.

KEEP READING

What to Do if You've Tested Positive

Similar conditions

Viral sore throat

The following symptoms suggest a virus, not strep throat, is the cause of a sore throat:

- Cough
- Runny nose
- Hoarseness (changes in voice to sound breathy, raspy or strained)
- Conjunctivitis (pink eye)

What's it mean to be a strep carrier?

Some people can test positive for group A strep bacteria but have no symptoms. Are they contagious? Do they need antibiotics?

Learn more about strep carriers

Resources

Conjunctivitis (pink eye)

SOURCES AND PAGE INFO

CONTENT SOURCE:

National Center for Immunization and Respiratory Diseases; Division of Bacterial Diseases

ABOUT THIS PAGE

Published: May 15, 2024

Updated: January 15, 2026

This page was last updated on this date. Updates may include minor edits, image changes, or other modifications to page content.

Reviewed: January 15, 2026

The information on this page was last reviewed by subject matter experts to ensure accuracy.